

favouritism in your departments.” The chief minister also told a conference of IAS and IPS officers in Lucknow to focus urgently on Dalit welfare schemes, ordered the director-general of police to visit the spot if a Dalit was killed or raped and has chalked out a detailed plan for herself to start visiting Dalit colonies from next month. “If you fail to perform, face serious action to the extent of going to jail and dismissal,” warned the chief minister, making it clear that she was back to playing the Dalit card. The ensuing silence betrayed the sense of hurt her ministers felt at being humiliated in the presence of their officers. Even if they blamed her privately for her obsession with installing her own statues all over the capital and demol-

for scapegoats. It was at her instance that red beacons appeared on vehicles of the kith and kin of influential BSP leaders as did the diktats of the so-called ministers of state, who were not only a headache for their institutions but could be seen calling the shots at police stations and district supply offices.

The experiment of strengthening the party at the cost of the exchequer has boomeranged. “If Mayawati fixes a certain amount in lakhs for ministers and MLAs to cough up on her birthday which is celebrated every year as *aarthik sahyog diwas* (financial assistance day), she should also know from where the

them,” says former director-general of police Prakash Singh.

Having realised that both her experiments—depending on musclemen for winning seats and her aggressive Brahmin card—have failed, Mayawati is actively considering going back to consolidating the core votebank of the BSP among Dalits. Addressing a conference of the rank and file of the party after the elections, Mayawati underplayed the Brahmin card and promised to not to deviate from the “ideals of Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar”. It remains to be seen what new social engineering trick she has up her sleeve to wow the electorate and disarm her detractors.

It was an ominous sign that the lights went out in the Yojana Bhawan

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ishing government bungalows, buildings, parks and stadia for her pet projects at a cost of thousands of crores of rupees, the rumblings are yet to become an uproar. Behenji's word is law, for now.

Far from taking responsibility for the poll debacle and reinvigorating her party, the chief minister—who is also the supremo of the ruling BSP—is quarrelling with her already demoralised and defeated army of leaders and workers and searching

money comes,” a senior minister told INDIA TODAY on condition of anonymity. Indeed, it was Mayawati who told a press conference on her birthday on January 14 that the donations were much higher this year.

Similarly, the BSP supremo cannot blame anyone for fielding 13 criminals and dons in the elections and compromising with her USP of being anti-criminal. “The presence of criminals and mafia dons in a political party reflects the attitude of the leadership towards

conference hall when Mayawati was berating her ministers. The BSP supremo then broke from her rant to scream at Power Minister Ramvir Upadhyaya, “*Jab yahan per yeh haal hai to gaon mein kya hoga* (when this is the power situation in my office, what would be the condition in villages)?” The light clearly seems to be out for Mayawati, or is it just the darkness before a new dawn? Three years and the next Assembly elections later, all will be known. ■